

# Staffing & Consultants

Generated: 2026-06-25 | Entries: 24

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**Q: How is the duration of short-term advisory support determined and what is the average duration of the provision of short-term advisory support? In this connection, it is noted that the criteria specify “short-term nature (i.e. conceived and implemented within less than two calendar years)” (para. 23.13 (c)(ii)). Yet, it is also stated that “extensions of advisers are reviewed on an annual basis” and that “while there is an annual review of the advisory skills needed during the next period, the positions are automatically redefined at the five-year mark to better respond to the changing needs of countries and to address new and emerging concerns” (para. 23.17). The latter two points would seem to indicate that RPTC-financed advisory support could last far longer than a two-year period.**

DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris. If possible, please provide an estimate of the duration of a typical short-term advisory activity.

The identification of the areas of focus is determined by the head of office based on emerging priorities and guidance by the implementing entity's governing body. The advisers' main function is to act as the entity's technical and policy advisory arm to Member States' governments by translating and contextualizing the Organization's policy directions and normative recommendations to the national and local levels. Through their integration with the sub-programmes and their regular contact with Member States governments, advisors are well placed to act as a bridge between the entity's normative and analytical work and operational work, reflecting on the relevance of the Organization's research agenda and providing key inputs into the technical cooperation activities.

Advisory services which ensure the provision of high-level technical expertise, the transfer of knowledge from global and regional entities to governments on policy related issues and development strategies and the formulation, assessment or evaluation of projects and programmes, are provided by these interregional and regional advisers. Consultants assist the advisers to respond to specific country requests by providing technical expertise which is not available in-house. Moreover, to maximise the impact of country level work, national consultants organize local follow-up actions to support the work of the advisers.

Advisors tend to serve for periods up to five years in a particular function. For example, an advisor on tax may during this period receive multiple requests from various countries for advice on the negotiation of double tax treaties or on designing national mechanism for the implementation of such treaties. Objective of the advisory role is to build local/national capacity to design and apply such treaties. Thus the implementing entity will review the changed needs by Member States, for example in the area of taxation, and revise the job description of the position regularly (latest after 5 years) to meet the revised requirements and priorities.

**Q: Paragraph 23.18 speaks of consultancy assignments to ensure expertise and knowledge of national and regional issues. How is that ensured? How the entities differentiate between the hiring of consultants, experts and individual contractors in the use of RPTC? JS - done**

DESA to provide a general response

The need for consultants is determined by the needs expressed by Member States and decisions taken by the implementing entities on how best to respond to the specific requirements of a country.

Advisory services which ensure the provision of high-level technical expertise, the transfer of knowledge from global and regional entities to governments on policy related issues and development strategies and the formulation, assessment or evaluation of projects and programmes, are provided by the interregional and regional advisers. Consultants assist the advisers to respond to specific country requests by providing technical expertise which is not available in-house. Moreover, to maximise the impact of country level work, national consultants organise local follow up actions to support the work of the advisers.

The Organisation engages individuals as consultants to provide specialist expertise in a specific field and they are engaged under a temporary contract in an advisory or consultative capacity. Typically, the programme engages consultants for results-oriented tasks within their area of expertise to respond to needs from countries that can be met in a short time-frame and do not require the continuous availability of the required expertise. Consultants work under the guidance of the staff of the sub-programme and report all their findings to them.

National level experts are consultants who are engaged to address country specific issues for which expert knowledge of national issues is fundamental in ensuring the most relevant and targeted support. In the context of national workshops, implementing entities rely on national experts to ensure the transfer of local knowledge and expertise as well as promote local follow-up actions.

ST/AI/2013/4 states that an individual contractor is an individual engaged by the Organization from time to time under a temporary contract to provide expertise, skills or knowledge for the performance of a specific task or piece of work, which would be short-term by nature, against the payment of an all-inclusive fee. The work assignment may involve full-time or part-time functions similar to those of staff members, such as the provision of translation, editing, language training, public information, secretarial or clerical and part-time maintenance services or other functions that could be performed by staff. An individual contractor need not work on United Nations premises.

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**Q: How is the strategic use of RPTC resources becoming more defined within the overall capacity-development strategy of the respective implementing agencies and used complementarily to other development funds, including the UN Development Account and**

**extra budgetary resources? How in practical terms are implementing entities working towards strengthening the linkages between RPTC-funded activities and the Development Account and extra-budgetary resources, as well as strengthening follow-through (paras 23.8 and 23.25)?**

DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris. The RPTC allows a fast and flexible response to requests from Member States through time-limited, focused advisory and/or training interventions within the substantive competencies of the implementing entities. The Development Account funds medium-term projects up to four years aimed at addressing specific problems and challenges from developing countries, resulting in concrete development impact which builds upon the initial assistance provided under the RPTC.

The RPTC implementing entities are responsible for determining the individual projects which will be funded using their allocations based on the individual demands they receive from Member States. Such projects would include the provision of advisory services by IRAs/regional advisers, staff and/or consultants; the organisation and implementation of training workshops/seminars; the sponsorship of fellowships; study tours and the implementation of small field projects. These activities involve project formulation, missions to countries to conduct needs assessments, preparation of project documents, brokering knowledge between countries and external expertise, developing substantive toolkits, building partner networks etc.. The tasks also involve programme planning and programme oversight to ensure that the limited funds are programmed effectively and are responsive to those most in need. The Development Account (DA) funds medium scale projects with an average budget of \$650,000, spanning a four-year period. The programming of the budget is entrusted to the USG for DESA, as the Programme Manager and involves the setting of a “theme” to guide the substantive focus of the projects, a call for proposals, an intensive review and selection process resulting in a short list endorsed by the DA Steering Committee and approved by the USG/DESA for GA approval. The day to day management of the DA has been entrusted to DESA's CDPMO and involves the review and vetting process of all project documents, continuous coordination with the implementing entities, monitoring implementation, review of all progress, final and evaluation reports and distilling lessons learned, issuance of various guidelines and training tools to strengthen project management etc.. The main tasks of the implementing entities are to: formulate solid project proposals which are responsive to the needs of Member States and which will result in concrete outcomes/results; ensure timely implementation of the project during the approved time frame and comply with all DA reporting requirements. The accomplishment of these tasks involves the administrative offices and substantive divisions within each implementing entity.

Implementing entities have been increasingly working towards strengthening the linkages between the Regular Programme for Technical Cooperation activities and the Development Account, as well as extra-budgetary resources, to create multiplier effects which contribute to longer-term sustained development results. Some entities have developed integrated work plans for their capacity-development activities to promote greater synergy across themes, as well as regional and in-country support, drawing on both funding sources. This strategic planning of the resources utilized in these important capacity development programmes, optimizes its impact through strengthened linkages.

**Q: Please explain more fully the need for the proposed increase under staff costs (\$619,700) under DESA. What is the current staff capacity and what is specifically being proposed in terms of additional staff capacity and for how long (Table 23.6, para. 23.55)? Please provide a description of the functions to be performed.**

DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris. The approved budget for 2021 provided for 22 Inter-Regional Adviser's posts. The same level is proposed for 2022. While the number of the IRA positions remains the same, the cost will increase because (a) increased standard salary costs (b) DESA applied higher vacancy rate in 2021 given that reprofiling of the required IRA positions was carried out in 2019 and 2020. Nearly half of the IRA positions were vacant at the beginning of 2020 and it took DESA the year of 2020 to fill these positions. DESA started 2021 with 3 vacancies but targets to fill all 22 positions before the end of 2021. The list of IRA positions and their expertise areas are in the attached list. In addition to the 22 IRAs there are four programme assistants positions to support the work of the IRAs.

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**Q: Please provide more detailed explanations on how the hybrid assistance will work and the link with the increase of 68.9% under the consultant component**

All entities please provide an example of how hybrid assistance has been used in either 2020 or 2021. For those entities with a proposed increase in resources for consultants (see Q 33), please provide a brief explanation of the linkage between hybrid support and the requirements for the increased use of consultants.

DESA:

Hybrid assistance will enable all entities to complement in-person activities with virtual activities, therefore allowing for more touchpoints between staff and beneficiaries/participants throughout the lifetime of projects and activities.

A few examples of hybrid assistance are:

Combining pre-recorded webinars with live discussions

Pairing in-person workshops with e-courses

Providing virtual advisory services after in-person discussions

Sharing micro-learning videos and courses to share important information before in-person briefings

Hybrid assistance is proven to help solidify knowledge including by allowing for more continuity and discussion during projects and other assistance as virtual modalities can provide greater flexibility, better sequencing and wider reach. The advantages of in-person assistance can be augmented by the benefits of virtual touchpoints allowing for longer engagement and more versatility in workshop/training

design. In some cases, where virtual activities offer an opportunity for participants of workshops/trainings to gather in person while the UN staff is facilitating remotely, local consultants can be an important link that work hand-in-hand with staff at the UN, ensuring a smooth and interactive workshop experience.

Local consultants will also be needed increasingly to prepare important data and research in preparation for in-person or virtual events as they have unique access, relationships and knowledge in their specific contexts. A reduction in the amount of travel of staff from non-resident agencies will naturally go hand-in-hand with an increase in reliance of consultants to prepare and summarize important findings, hence the estimated increase in budget for consultancy.

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**Q: Please update the GTA table provided in SI by adding numbers and total for each entity and total for all, status of incumbency, recruitment status**

All entities, please confirm the list of GTA for your entity were all encumbered as of 30 April 2021.  
DESA:

Confirm there has not been any change since 30 April 2021

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sub-programme and report all their findings to them.

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DESA is requested to provide the response based on the verbal responses from Mr. Harris. (REVISED) The approved budget for 2021 provided for 22 Inter-Regional Adviser's posts. While the proposed number of IRA positions is the same, the cost will increase because the number of months the GTA require would increase by 30 months at P5 level in order to respond to the anticipated emerging needs to recover and rebuild back better from the pandemic. The list of IRA positions and their expertise areas are in the attached list. In addition to the 22 IRAs there are four programme assistants positions to support the work of the IRAs.

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**Q: Much of ACABQ comments of last year remain in the status quo in this programme. Why is this the case?**

5.1 In its resolution 77/262 of 20 December 2022, the General Assembly endorsed the recommendations made by the ACABQ related to the RPTC in its report A/77/7. In response, the OIOS and the implementing entities initiated work on an evaluation of section 23, the RPTC. The OIOS is

expected to complete its report early in 2024 and present it to the CPC in May and the General Assembly in Autumn of 2024. The evaluation will consider the relevancy, effectiveness, coherence and efficiency of the RPTC. In this context the Secretariat is awaiting the outcome of the evaluation as well as any issues that are raised during the consideration of the report by the committees which may inform the Secretariat before establishing any new formal coordination mechanisms, evaluation frameworks, and the various other recommendations from A/78/8.

5.2 In relation to the recommendation on reviewing the general temporary positions of the RPTC (A/77/8, paragraph V.93), and the use of RPTC funds, especially in relation to the use and management of inter-regional Advisors, DESA has taken actions in reviewing the inter-regional adviser (IRA) posts and duration under DESA management. Over the years, IRAs under DESA has been providing valuable support to Member States, in responding to their needs, and more importantly, in transforming the overall policies and decisions from the Member States at the Headquarters to concrete capacity building actions on the ground. Their work has been widely appreciated by Member States.

5.3 In reviewing the current IRA functions and roles under DESA, the secretariat aims to leverage DESA RPTC resources as an impactful, and responsive tool to help Member States accelerate the implementation of the 2030 Agenda. DESA is in the process of formulating a set of new policies under the guidance of the USG, to strategically programme RPTC resources and activities, and align us more closely with UNSDCF through coordination with the RC system, and to meet the changing demands and expectations. DESA will take concrete actions to a more flexible IRA team, with changing priorities, and a more balanced ratio of post level and post resources.

5.4 In addition, in response to the ACABQ's recommendation "that a clear governance, coordination and evaluation mechanism should be established at the global, regional and local levels, and considers that the Department of Economic and Social Affairs and the Development Coordination Office should have a leading role in focusing on coordination and evaluation at the global level. (para V.106)" the implementing entities have engaged in consultations at various levels to prepare a review report, which will be finalized after taking into consideration the recommendations of the OIOS report on the overall performance of RPTC, and which will inform the 2025 fascicle on the proposed programme budget for RPTC.

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**Q: Please elaborate in more detail on the implementation of the Committee's recommendation endorsed by the Assembly on the review of the GTAs. What was done by the entities, was there a general criterion used by the entities in doing the review? What was the result of the review? Please list positions that were discontinued, if any, and the reasoning behind it.**

6.1 In addition to the information provided in the response to question 6 in this set, DESA is currently conducting a review of its GTA positions, with a focus on the IRA positions, including functions, levels and duration of contract. This review is led by the USG and DESA's RPTC guidelines on the use and

management of IRAs will be revised based on the final outcomes, expected in the fall. It should be noted that the General Assembly approved the Committee's recommendations on 30 December 2022, and the revised guidelines are expected to be available in time to inform the proposed programme budget for 2025.

6.2 For the OHCHR, the most recent review of GTAs was completed on 17th February 2023. For 2024, OHCHR plans to propose the expansion of the number of positions under the GTA segment to support the implementation of technical cooperation activities in the field.

6.3 ECE plans to maintain the same level of staffing requirements with some possible changes in the level of its regional advisors (RAs) and ECE is currently working on the best institutional RPTC model, which is to be finalized by the end of 2023, taking into account the ongoing RPTC evaluation currently conducted by OIOS. Based on this model, and related criterion, ECE plans to conduct a review of GTA positions.

6.4 ECLAC periodically undertakes a revision of the GTA positions and the need for their continuation, taking into account requests from member States for technical support in the specific area of expertise.

6.5 In ESCAP, all current Regional Advisors' positions (two P-5 positions, three P-4 positions), are expected to remain in 2024. ESCAP established a Departmental Panel in 2018 to review all proposed Regional Advisor positions. The related Guidelines on the Recruitment and Administration of Regional Advisors were updated in 2023.

6.6 ESCWA plans to maintain the same level of staffing requirements. In determining its needs, ESCWA carries out periodic reviews of existing GTA positions and the need for their continuation. This is based on an assessment of existing requests directly received from member States. In addition, these needs are determined based on the anticipated areas of work that are identified through the intergovernmental machinery of the Commission for technical cooperation support.

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**Q: Please provide a breakdown of the elements that make up the other staff costs category. What is the equivalent staff number?**

7.1 The other staff category consists of general temporary resources, other personnel costs and overtime and night differential. Within the GTA subclass the main elements are the staff salaries and related common staff costs.

Category 2024 proposed amount (before recosting)

GTA \$23,856,700

Other personnel costs \$75,000

Overtime and night differential \$74,600

Total \$24,006,300

7.2 The equivalent full time staff numbers are as follows:

Entity | P+ level staff | GS and equivalent | Total

DESA | 3 P-6, 18 P-5, 2 P-4 | 7 GS (OL) | 30

UNCTAD | 2 P-5, 2 P-3 | - | 4  
UN-Habitat | 3 P-5 | 1 GS (OL) | 4  
UNODC | 2 P-4 | - | 2  
OHCHR | 3 P-4, 2 P-3, 3 NPO | 2 GS | 10  
OCHA | 1 P-4, 1 P-3, and 1 P-2 | - | 3  
ECA | 5 D-1, 4 P-5, 1 P-3, 2 NPO | 20 LL | 32  
ESCAP | 2 P-5, 3 P-4 | - | 5  
ECE | 4 P-5, 2 P-4 | - | 6  
ECLAC | 5 P-5, 7 P-4, 2 P-3 | 8 GS (OL) | 22  
ESCWA | 1 D-1, 5 P-5, 7 P-4, 10 P-3, 1 NPO | 1 GS (PL) and 2 GS (OL) | 27  
Total | | 145

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**Q: For the 8th progress report, please provide detailed information on what are the common reporting standards that were adopted.**

The 7th RPTC Progress Report highlighted the lack of standardised data collection methods between the 11 Implementing Entities (IEs) as an issue to be addressed. Having considered the Progress Report, the ACABQ recommended that Common Reporting Standards for RPTC activities be developed. To this end, a consultant was contracted by DESA who worked with the IEs to develop ‘a minimum common standard for reporting on their RPTC activities’. The key issues which the Common Standards aimed to address are, notably: simplification of reporting; agreeing on the meaning of key terms; agreeing how to treat “Country Support”; recognizing the reality of virtual support; recognizing the complications of attributing impact to RPTC activities; agreeing how to monitor RPTC events; standardizing terminology used for the outputs of RPTC; and helping IEs make small changes to their Programme Monitoring Tools. For further information, please refer to the Common Reporting Standards document in Annex II of this set of responses.

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**Q: What are the roles and responsibilities of DESA and the implementing entities and the resident coordinator and agencies in the country? Is there a dedicated capacity in DESA for this programme?**

Please refer to the response provided for question 53 in this set. In addition, the RPTC is managed in a decentralized manner and DESA is one of the 11 implementing entities. DESA does not play any

coordination role within the RPTC funding on behalf of other implementing entities. Presently, the dedicated capacity in DESA to manage DESA's portion of the funds of the RPTC programme consist of one P-4.

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**Q: RPTC versus Development Account – Please clarify further why both programmes cannot be housed under one Division or Office, with two types of funding models. The response that RPTC is more agile, while the DA is more long term does not preclude this happening. It will also cause a staffing review to be done to see what is really needed. How many staff are devoted to RPTC and how many to the DA?**

13.1 The development account (DA) and the RPTC have similar objectives, but their programming, implementation, monitoring and evaluation approaches are distinctly different. The DA funds medium-term interventions that are executed over a period of up to four years at primarily subregional, but also regional and global levels, targeting specific countries and focusing on their particular development needs. The RPTC funds short-term, small-scale, demand-driven, specific interventions responding in a flexible manner to often urgent and not easily predictable national development needs. Many of these interventions are executed by experienced regular staff members or regional and interregional advisers funded from the regular programme of technical cooperation and assigned to various economic and social entities of the Secretariat. Its current decentralized modality is considered to be most effective.

13.2 The RPTC has a substantial general temporary assistance (GTA) component which allows the implementing entities to secure the services of sectoral and cross-sectoral development specialists, while the human resource component of the Development Account is small and does not support staff posts. Both programmes operate in the broader UN development system, including funds, programmes and specialized agencies, and aim at filling capacity development gaps in niche areas that fall outside the priorities and expertise of other development organizations. There is no direct coordination between the RPTC and DA as the RPTC is managed in a completely decentralised way at the level of each implementing entity. Each entity has mechanisms in place at programme and subprogramme level to ensure consistency and synergy. For example, in DESA the Capacity Development Programme Management Office has this function. For the sub-programmes, it is the Director of the sub-programme who has a good overview of the planned activities financed from RPTC, DA and extrabudgetary resources and will ensure that these activities build on each other and do not duplicate. The same staff resources may be used for both programmes.

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**Q: Out of the resource requirements for the programme, how much actually goes to the projects and the countries in need (not to staff, consultants, etc.)?**

4.1 The resources of the RPTC, section 23 ultimately benefit the countries in need. The RPTC does not provide money directly to developing countries, instead it funds advisory positions that provide advisory services to developing countries as well as customized training to respond to the demands of the countries. The RPTC enables developing countries to access the expertise available in the regional and global implementing entities of the programme.

4.2 The RPTC links to work funded from various sources which may include resources from the entities' own regular budget section, such as Section 9 for DESA, extrabudgetary resources and the Development Account, resulting in the actual value of expertise/advice that reaches the countries in need is well above the amount funded through the RPTC.

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**Q: What is the particular role played by the HQ-based interregional advisors?**

**DESA**

Inter-regional advisors are key enablers of the goals of the RPTC, in delivering agile capacity development support to Member States. They are specialists in both capacity development and in the substantive area of the sub-programmes. They are DESA's technical and policy advisory arm to Member States by translating and contextualizing the department's policy directions and normative recommendations to the national and local levels, thereby facilitating country-level access to DESA's expertise

**UNCTAD**

Overall, the role of the HQ-based Interregional Advisers is to ensure the provision of technical advice and assistance to Member States on policy options and their implications, both directly and by drawing on already existing expertise within UNCTAD.

More specifically, this role is two-fold, as follows:

With the support of the substantive divisions of UNCTAD, inter-regional advisors provide on-demand technical advisory services to developing countries (including LDCs, LLDCs and SIDS, as well as countries with economies in transition) on policy options and their implications, and related technical assistance opportunities, and lead advisory missions. They also coordinate substantive communications with Member States in regard to UNCTAD's advisory services and provide advice to Member States on existing opportunities for technical assistance.

At the same time, the Interregional Advisers also provide high-level strategic advice to the Secretary-General of UNCTAD and senior management on the direction, design, implementation, monitoring and assessment of UNCTAD-wide advisory services to developing countries and countries with economies in transition, as well as on maximizing complementarity among different funding sources of UNCTAD's technical cooperation activities.

**UN-Habitat**

The main functions of the headquarter-based Inter-regional advisers (IRAs) are to provide: (a)

short-term advisory services on strategically selected, high-priority issues; (b) the identification, development and launch of innovative and illustrative cooperation programmes, and; (c) specialized support to the implementation, monitoring and replication of such cooperation programmes. The aim is to support governments and partners in their efforts to meet their commitments and make their contributions to the implementation of the New Urban Agenda, the human settlements dimension of other multilateral agreements, such as the Sustainable Development Goals contained in the 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda, with a focus on Goal 11 promoting an integrated, holistic and universal approach to urbanization. Each IRA focuses on selected areas of work which are catalytic to the implementation of the Strategic Plan 2020 – 2023, namely, the localization of SDGs in Africa, establishment of regional presence in Eastern Europe and Central Asia as well as supporting South-South Cooperation.

UNODC

The HQ-based inter-regional adviser provides support to all RPTC-related proposals to be implemented in the field, with a focus on criminal justice reform and corrections. In particular, policy and legislative advice, delivery of training, and advisory services. The Adviser annually undertakes an average of seven field missions within RPTC-funded proposals.

The proposed new position at the P-4 level will be posted in Africa and will support the field offices of the region to expand youth-focused programming and related resource mobilization.

ECA (as an example for all the Regional Commissions)

The main function of the HQ based Inter-regional Advisers is to provide technical expertise, facilitate the transfer of knowledge from global deliberations and latest analytical work to governments and institutions and contribute to the formulation, assessment and/or evaluation of national and subregional policies, strategies, programmes and projects of member States and regional economic communities upon their requests. The specific roles/functions/areas of expertise are reflected in the job descriptions/terms of reference (TORs) and are classified at the appropriate level. The specific focus of each of these positions evolves over time in line with the Commission's strategic intervention tracks, shifting member state priorities, regional trends, and so forth. Even though the advisors are based at HQ, they cover the regions upon member States request for services pertaining to their programmatic expertise.

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**Q: Regarding para 11 first sentence, please specify all programmes, their implementing agencies and the countries concerned where non-resident agencies have NOT entered into institutional cooperation agreements with resident agencies, together with explanations as to how resident agencies or country teams are engaged otherwise.**

11c.1 DESA, in close coordination with the Development Coordination Office (DCO), has developed standard operating procedures (SOPs) on how to engage with the RC/RCO when planning, organizing and conducting operational activities for sustainable development and other activities in ways that are in line with the new role of the RC, the UNSDCF1 and the new

Management and Accountability Framework (MAF) 2 for a reinvigorated resident coordinator system. Activities funded from the RPTC are often short-term in nature in response to an expressed need from a country and require rapid responses without requiring institutional cooperation agreements, but nevertheless follow the operating procedures to ensure coordination with the RC/RCO and the UN country team. Formal cooperation agreements may be more useful for longer-term interventions that are often formulated building on the knowledge acquired during the initial intervention funded from the RPTC. Such follow-up activities or projects are often funded by the Development Account.

11c.2 When a request is received from a Member State, the implementing entity reviews whether the request meets the criteria indicated in paragraph 23.13 of the proposed programme budget A/75/6 (Sect 23). If this is the case, the implementing entity will plan and execute the response to the request, including assigning an individual or a team of advisors supported by regular staff and short-term consultants as appropriate. Intervention at country-level is coordinated with the UN Resident Coordinator and the UN Country Teams to ensure synergies with the country-level development work. This cooperation can include joint programming through the common country assessment and the United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework.

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**Q: What does other staff costs include? Please provide a breakdown. Are the costs related to dedicated staff in DESA administering the Programme, including monitoring and evaluation?**

4.1 The RPTC proposed budget for 2021 includes resources totalling \$18,911,000, before recosting, under the class Other staff costs. These resources would provide for the requirements for the general temporary assistance positions for 2021. The details on the current GTA positions in the RPTC are listed in the response to question 25 provided to the Committee on 21 July 2020.

4.2 The administration and management of the RPTC resources is a collective responsibility of: a) executive direction and management; b) programme support, i.e. executive offices/divisions of administration, and; c) substantive divisions/technical cooperation sections.

4.3 In the case of DESA, the Capacity Development Programme Management Office (CDPMO) is responsible for day to day programmatic management of the programme, while the substantive divisions are responsible for programming and implementation of the activities. Administrative support for RPTC transactions, such as management of staff contracts, consultant contracts or travel of advisors and workshop participants are provided by various staff within CDPMO. This office provides the administrative support to all DESA's capacity development activities and thus the respective staff also support projects funded by extrabudgetary resources and Development Account.

4.4 In summary, monitoring and evaluation, and administration of the RPTC are performed by staff under the respective budget sections of the implementing entities, where the existing

management and administrative support structures are also involved in the budget preparation, implementation, reporting and evaluation of Section 23. Under these arrangements, RPTC resources are used exclusively for planning and implementation of RPTC-funded activities.

4.5 DESA implements the programme using complementary mechanisms for the provision of advisory services. These include regular staff members and short-term advisers who respond to very specific, distinct assignments of a limited duration as well as consultant assignments, where national and regional expertise are drawn upon. Advisers translate and contextualize DESA's policy directions and normative recommendations to the national and local levels. Through their integration with the sub-programmes and their regular contact with member governments, advisers are well placed to act as a bridge between DESA's normative and operational work, reflecting on the relevance of the DESA's research agenda and providing key input into the technical cooperation projects and programmes.

4.6 DESA also relies on national or regional institutions such as government institutions and other UN entities resident in the country and regional bodies such as African Tax Administration Forum, particularly in the context of national and regional workshops which ensure the transfer of local knowledge and expertise and promote local follow up actions.

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**Q: Why there is change in resources requested among sub-programmes if there is no change to the overall resources is requested? What are the reasons for the changes?**

14.1 The explanations for the proposed resource changes within the subprogrammes are provided in the budget report paragraphs (DESA 23.32, 23.38, 23.44, 23.50, 23.58, 23.65, 23.71 and 23.76; ECA 23.139, 23.144, 23.150 and 23.156; ESCAP 23.173, 23.178, 23.184, 23.189, 23.195, 23.201, 23.207, 23.236 and 23.243; ECE 23.250, 23.256, 23.262, 23.268, 23.274, 23.280 and 23.286, and; ESCWA 23.351, 23.363 and 23.368). There are two other entities, UNODC and OCHA (subprogramme 1), with subprogrammes which had no overall change in resources but had some proposed changes within the budget classes.

UNODC

14.2 The proposed resources for 2021 reflect (i) an internal transfer of resources from the fellowships, grants and contributions to contractual service to align the budget with the nature of expense, and (ii) and increase under consultants and expert to reflect the expected increase in consultant services for the implementation of field-based initiatives following a strategic long-term approach.

OCHA (Subprogramme 1. Policy and analysis)

14.3 The proposed resources for 2021 amount to \$152,100 and reflects no resource change compared with the appropriation for 2020. Proposed increase in resources for consultants (\$36,600) and travel of staff (\$10,800) are offset by decreases in resources for other staff (\$37,800), contractual services (\$5,400) and general operating expenses (\$4,200) due to the plan to focus on policy research and expert group consultations in 2021.

**Q: Please provide a breakdown of other staff costs and explain the reduction under consultants.**

28.1 Please refer to the response provided to question 4, above for details of the breakdown of Other staff costs. The proposed decrease in resources for consultants are mainly due to decreases in subprogramme 9 of DESA and subprogrammes 4 and 5 of the ECA.

**DESA**

28.2 In addition to the information provided in the response to question 21 above, the proposed decrease in resources for Consultants (\$395,700) in subprogramme 9 reflects the reduced requirement for consulting services in line with the subprogramme's anticipated level of requests for assistance.

28.3 This changes is related to the proposed addition of two interregional advisers on investment and financing for development, the continuation of the work streams on integrated national financing frameworks and the implementation of further capacity-building activities for developing countries on mobilizing private investment for sustainable development, and a reduced requirement for consulting services and fellowships in line with the subprogramme's anticipated level of requests for assistance.

28.4 The proposed RPTC resources for DESA as a whole in 2021 reflect the existing and projected demands from Member States as well as the corresponding activities that are planned which include the portfolio of Inter-regional advisors among the subprogrammes. Following a review by the Department's Capacity Development Steering Committee of the composition of its 2021 portfolio of Inter-regional Advisors and in view of trends in demands for sectoral advisory services, it became apparent that advisors were needed to respond in an integrated manner to Member States' requests on various socio economic issues and policies as well as to advise developing countries on the integration of the findings of their voluntary national reviews into their national sustainable development strategies.

**ECA**

28.5 The proposed decrease in resources for Consultants reflecting a reduced reliance on consultants, is largely offset by an increase under Other staff costs reflecting the level of staffing resources needed to meet the anticipated level of requests from member States.

28.6 The reduced use of Consultants would enable ECE to provide additional resources under Other staff costs for the provision for an additional Regional Advisor at the D-1 level to spearhead the cluster on "Data and Statistics" in responding to the high demand for advisory services from member states in the area of Statistics and Big data management.

**Q: Question 3. Out of the resource requirements for the programme, how much actually goes to the projects and the countries in need (not to staff, consultants, etc.)?**

2.1 The resources of the section 23 ultimately benefits the countries in need. While the RPTC does not provide money directly to developing countries it funds advisory positions that provide advisory services to developing countries as well as customized training to respond to country demand. The RPTC enables developing countries to access the expertise available in the regional and global implementing entities of the programme.

2.2 As also highlighted in the 7th Progress Report, the RPTC links to work funded from various sources which may include resources from the entities' own regular budget section, such as Section 9 for DESA, extrabudgetary resources and the Development Account, resulting in the actual value of expertise/advice that reaches the countries in need is well above the amount funded through the RPTC. For example, approximately 285 staff, who were not funded by RPTC, were involved in the delivery of RPTC activities in 2021 (please refer to chapter 5.3 of the 7th Progress Report of the RPTC which can be found in the supplementary information starting at page).

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**Q: Question 9b. Please remind the Committee on the difference between the RPTC and the Development Account and the areas of synergies and overlap? How do they complement one another?).**

5.1 While the Development Account (DA) and the RPTC have similar objectives, their programming, implementation, monitoring and evaluation approaches are distinctly different. The DA funds medium-term interventions that are executed over a period of up to four years at primarily subregional, but also regional and global levels, targeting specific countries and focusing on their particular development needs.

5.2 The RPTC funds short-term, small-scale, demand-driven, specific interventions responding in a flexible manner to often urgent and not easily predictable national development needs. Many of these interventions are executed by experienced regular staff members or regional and interregional advisers funded from the regular programme of technical cooperation and assigned to various economic and social entities of the Secretariat.

5.3 The RPTC has a substantial general temporary assistance (GTA) component which allows the organization to secure the services of sectoral and cross-sectoral development specialists, while the human resource component of the Development Account is small and does not support staff positions.

5.4 Both programmes operate in the broader UN development system, including funds, programmes and specialized agencies, and aim at filling capacity development gaps in niche areas that fall outside the priorities and expertise of other development organizations.

5.5 There is no direct coordination between the RPTC and DA as the RPTC is managed in a completely decentralised way. Each entity has mechanisms in place at programme and sub-programme level to ensure consistency and synergy. For example, in DESA the Capacity

Development Programme Management Office has this function. For the sub-programmes, it is the Director of the sub-programme who has a good overview of the planned activities financed from RPTC, DA and extrabudgetary resources and will ensure that these activities build on each other and do not duplicate.

United Nations NationsUnies

INTEROFFICE MEMORANDUM MEMORANDUM INTERIEUR

RPTC

Response No. 1

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**Q: Question 30. Has there been an assessment about how effective is the face-to-face, during intergovernmental meetings outreach that is used by most entities been assessed in terms of how is it appropriate for ensuring the demand driven character of the programme reaches its maximum potential? Has there been any consideration given to using the RC as the appropriate channel to inform Member States of instruments that are available, at the same time offering them a formal process to submit those requests?**

18.1 As an example the coordination between the implementing entities and the Resident Coordinators Offices, DESA, in close coordination with the Development Coordination Office (DCO), has developed standard operating procedures (SOPs) on how to engage with the Resident Coordinator/Resident Coordinators Office (RC/RCO) when planning, organizing and conducting operational activities for sustainable development and other activities in ways that are in line with the new role of the RC, the United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework (UNSDCF) and the new Management and Accountability Framework (MAF) for a reinvigorated resident coordinator system. Activities funded from the RPTC are short-term in nature in response to an expressed need from a country and require rapid responses without requiring institutional cooperation agreements, but nevertheless follow the operating procedures to ensure coordination with the RC/RCO and the UN country team. Formal cooperation agreements may be more useful for longer term interventions that are often formulated building on the knowledge acquired during United Nations NationsUnies

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the initial intervention funded from the RPTC. Such follow-up activities or projects are often funded by the Development Account.

18.2 When a request is received from a Member State, the implementing entity reviews whether the request meets the criteria indicated in paragraph 23.13 of the proposed programme budget A/77/6 (Sect 23). If this is the case, the implementing entity would plan and execute the response to the request, including assigning an individual or a team of advisors supported by regular staff and short-term consultants as appropriate. Intervention at country-level is coordinated with the UN Resident Coordinator and the UN Country Teams to ensure synergies with the country-level

development work. This cooperation can include joint programming through the common country assessment (CCA) and the United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework (UNSDCF).

18.3 Since 2020, DESA contributed to 49 CCAs, 13 Socio-economic Impact Assessments (SEIAs), signed eight UNCT memberships and contributed to 12 additional UNSDCFs, focussing on LDCs and SIDS. The engagement in the CCA/CF processes has enabled DESA to draw more fully from its normative and analytical resources to support country-level work and its collaboration with the RC system especially through the CCA/CF process has expanded DESA entry points and scope for country level support beyond capacity development work and country level operations.

18.4 Please refer to the responses provided to questions 4, 5 and 11 on the effectiveness of in-person activities.

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**Q: Please provide details of the national consultants that were engaged.**

2.1 The following implementing entities engaged consultants to work on support to member States in their country of nationality: ESCAP; ECE, ESCWA and DESA.

**ESCAP**

In 2018 and 2019 (1 January 2018 to 30 April 2019), ESCAP has engaged a total 138 consultants and individual contractors engagements across all subprogrammes using RPTC funds. Out of 138 engagements, 89 were carried out by consultants or individual contractors that were from Asia and the Pacific, representing 64 per cent of total engagements. From those, 26 are consultants and individual contractors who carried out activities in the country of their nationality, representing a share of 19 per cent of all engagements.

**ECE**

ECE has engaged 5 national consultants during the 2018-2019 period on the following thematic areas: Economic Cooperation and Trade in Azerbaijan to develop the methodology of data harmonization and development of a data model and a set of data aligned with international standards to be used in electronic documents and in Belarus for an assessment of the readiness of Belarus on each measure (legal texts, procedures, actual implementation) and for a recommendation for categorization; Forests land and Housing in Belarus to develop training materials on the development and implementation of national policies and programmes on affordable and energy efficient housing and in Kazakhstan to develop outline for the long-term national forestry strategy and to develop a roadmap for the long-term national forestry strategy.

**ESCWA**

ESCWA has engaged national consultants in: Jordan to support the establishment of a national E-Government Strategy, advise on data protection law and provide an advisory report on rights of way; Morocco to advise on cyber-crime laws and tariffs on agricultural trade, and; Tunisia on constitutional design to combat corruption and accession to Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA).

#### DESA

DESA has engaged 12 consultants to support its work in the following thematic areas: A Comprehensive Programme of Older Persons in Kyrgyzstan; Sustainable Forest Management in Iran and North Macedonia; Active ageing and youth policies in Moldova; Modelling techniques for sustainable development in Nicaragua, and; Urban land management in Tanzania and Uganda.

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